

O What Is That Sound by W.H. Auden

By

ARK

ABOUT POET

- Wystan Hugh Auden was born in the year 1907 in York in England.
- He was an English- American poet applauded especially for his technical and stylistic achievements and for his ability to write in any form of verse.
- He rose to fame with 'Poems' published in the year 1930. His most notable works include 'Funeral Blues', 'September 1, 1939', 'The Age of Anxiety' and 'For the Time Being'. He won the Pulitzer Prize in Poetry in 1947 for The Age of Anxiety. A man both controversial and influential.
- Auden died in the 1973 of natural causes.

Summary & Publication

- **"O What Is That Sound" is a ballad by W. H. Auden, written in October 1932 and first published in 1934.**
- *'O What Is That Sound'* by W.H. Auden discusses how two people can be so dedicated to each other but when imminent danger (war) is near it is every person for themselves.

MEANING AND THEMES

- Auden selected the title as '*O What Is That Sound*'. It is a very casual title, but when taken in the context of the poem it is understandable because most people during wartime were casually living their daily lives.
- When they were attacked by soldiers, they had their lives destroyed forever. As well as this, the title is deliberately archaic, which makes it hard for the reader to distinguish when Auden is referring to this poem about war.

MEANING AND THEMES

- Things may not be what they seem
- By doing this, it provides a universal message towards the war that it is not dependent on time but produces the same devastating effects regardless of when war takes place.
- Towards the end of the poem, the husband deserts his wife out of fear of the soldiers and this exemplifies the second most important theme, apart from the war that Auden is addressing, which is the concept of human nature. Two individuals can love one another, but when it comes to life or death situations, a person nearly always chooses himself or herself.

MEANING AND THEMES

- “Appearance vs reality.”
- The poem, ‘*O What Is That Sound*’ gives the reader a first-hand experience of how something may seem like another thing from far but when examined closely it is entirely different. This phenomenon of “things may not be what they seem,” occurs twice in the poem, first with the ‘thrilling’ sound being the dreaded sound of soldiers marching, and secondly with the marriage. The husband and wife spoke to each other endearingly throughout the poem so it seemed like there was much love between the two, however towards the end of the poem the husband leaves her once again reaffirming that things are not necessarily what they appear to be. In literature, this theme is also known as “appearance vs reality.”

STRUCTURE

- The poem is in ballad form and consists of seven stanzas.
- Being a ballad, each stanza consists of four rhyming lines. In each quatrain (four-line stanza), the poet uses a conventional rhyme scheme. It is not that of a typical ballad stanza.
- Here, the poet uses the ABAB rhyme scheme instead of the ABCB rhyme scheme.
- The latter rhyme scheme is used in conventional ballad form. Apart from that, the lines rhyme alternatively and capture two voices.
- Along with that, the poet uses repetitions and internal rhyming for maintaining the flow and rhythm of the poem.
- Besides, the overall poem is composed in iambic pentameter, iambic tetrameter, and iambic diameter alternatively. There are also some metrical variations in this poem.

LITERARY DEVICES

- Throughout the entire poem, '*O What Is That Sound*' Auden uses the repetition of words to create a feeling of fear and anxiety. For instance, the lines, "What are they doing this morning this morning?/ Over the distance brightly, brightly?" contain the repetition of "morning" and "brightly".
- This beautiful repetition not only creates anxiety but also consistently reminds the reader that the soldiers are marching throughout the poem as the repetition sounds rhythmic just as marching does.

LITERARY DEVICES

- Moreover, the poet uses apostrophe at the beginning of each stanza.
- One can find the use of alliteration in “scarlet soldiers.”
- There are several rhetorical questions or interrogations in every stanza.
- Thereafter, one can find the use of irony in the lines, “Perhaps a change in their orders, dear,/ None of these forces.”
- There is a palilogy in the line, “Is it the parson, is it, is it?” In the last two stanzas, Auden uses sarcasm and irony as well. Moreover, the poet uses a metaphor in the last line, “And their eyes are burning.”

THANK YOU